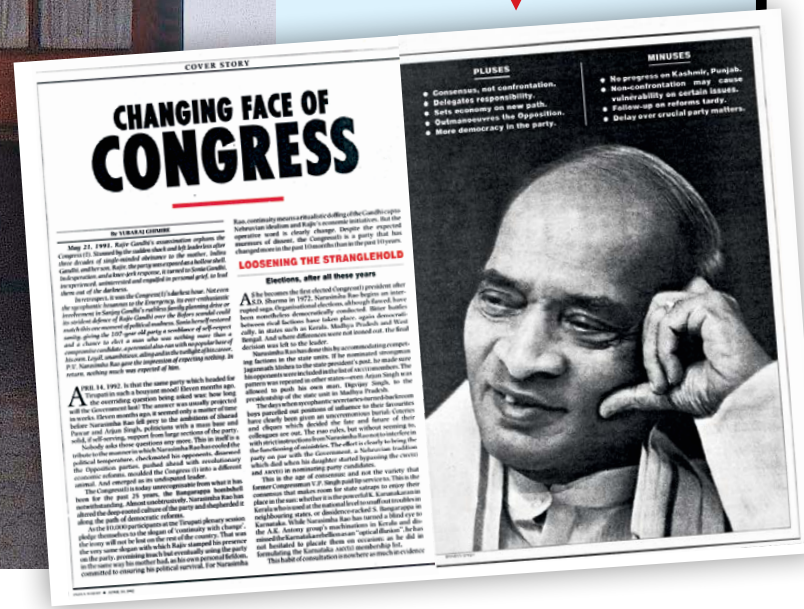


SHARAD SAXENA

SONIA GANDHI

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Changing Face of Congress
INDIA TODAY, *Apr. 30, 1992*



COVER STORY

CHANGING FACE OF CONGRESS

By SUBHASH GHIMIRE

May 21, 1991. Rajiv Gandhi's assassination orphans the Congress(I). Stunned by the sudden shock and left leaderless after three decades of single-minded obedience to the mother, Indira Gandhi and her son, Rajiv, the party was expected to flutter about incoherently, uninterested and engulfed in personal grief, to lead them out of the darkness.

In retrospect, it was the Congress(I)'s darkest hour. Not even the sycophantic hosannas to the Emergency, its over-enthusiastic involvement in Sanjay Gandhi's ruthless family planning drive or its strident defence of Rajiv Gandhi over the Bofors scandal could match this one moment of political madness. Sonia herself restored sanity, giving the 107-year-old party a semblance of self-respect and a chance to elect a man who was nothing more than a compromise candidate, a perennial also-ran with no popular base of his own. Loyal, unambitious, ailing and the toothpaste of his career, P.V. Narasimha Rao gave the impression of expecting nothing. In return, nothing much was expected of him.

APRIL 14, 1992. Is that the same party which headed for Tirupati in such a buoyant mood? Eleven months ago, the overriding question being asked was: how long will the Government last? The answer was usually projected in weeks. Eleven months ago, it seemed only a matter of time before Narasimha Rao left party to the auditions of Sharad Pawar and Arjun Singh, politicians with a mass base and solid, if self-serving, support from large sections of the party.

Nobody asks those questions any more. This in itself is a tribute to the manner in which Narasimha Rao has cooled the political temperature, checkmated his opponents, disowned the Opposition parties, pushed ahead with revolutionary economic reforms, moulded the Congress (I) into a different animal. And emerged as its undisputed leader.

The Congress(I) is today unrecognisable from what it has been for the past 25 years, the Rangarajan bombshell notwithstanding. Almost unobtrusively, Narasimha Rao has altered the deep-rooted culture of the party and shepherded it along the path of democratic reforms.

At the 81,000-participants-at-the-Tirupati-plenary session pledge themselves to the slogan of 'continuity with change', the irony will not be lost on the rest of the country. That was the very same slogan with which Rajiv stamped his presence on the party, promising less but eventually using the party in the same way his mother had, as his own personal fiefdom, committed to ensuring his political survival. For Narasimha Rao, continuity means a remarkable shifting of the Gandhi-capita Nehruvian idealism and Rajiv's economic initiatives. But the operative word is clearly change. Despite the expected murmurs of dissent, the Congress(I) is a party that has changed more in the past 10 months than in the past 10 years.

LOOSENING THE STRANGLEHOLD

Elections, after all these years

After becomes the first elected Congress(I) president after A.C.D. Sharma in 1972, Narasimha Rao begins an inter-rupted saga. Organisational elections, although flawed, have been nonetheless democratically conducted. Since battles between rival factions have taken place, again democrati-cally, in states such as Kerala, Madhya Pradesh and West Bengal. And where differences were not ironed out, the final decision was left to the leader.

Narasimha Rao has done this by accommodating competing factions in the state units. If he nominated strongmen to the state president's post, he made sure Jagannath Kishore to the state president's post, he made sure his opponents were included in the list of vice-presidents. The his opponents were included in the list of vice-presidents. The pattern was repeated in other states—even Arjun Singh was allowed to push his own man, Digvijay Singh, to the presidentship of the state unit in Madhya Pradesh.

The days when sycophants secretaries-turned-backroom boys parcelled out positions of influence to their favourites have clearly been given an unceremonious burial. Cronies and cliques which derided the late and lamented by colleagues are out. The rules, but without seeming to with strict instructions from Narasimha Rao not to interfere in the functioning of committees. The effort is clearly to keep the party on par with the Government, a Nehruvian tradition which died when his daughter started bypassing the circuit and NEWS in nominating party candidates.

This is the age of consensus and not the variety that former Congressmen V.P. Singh and his partners in. This is the consensus that makes room for state satraps to enjoy their place in the sun: whether it is the powerful K. Karunakaran in Kerala who is out at the national level to snuff out troublesome neighbouring states, or dissidents-cracked S. Bangarappa in Karnataka. While Narasimha Rao has turned a blind eye to the A.K. Antony group's machinations in Kerala and dismissed the Karnataka rebellion as an "optical illusion", he has not hesitated to placate them on occasions, as he did in formulating the Karnataka MEGO membership list.

This habit of consultation is nowhere as much in evidence

PLUSES
- Consensus, not confrontation.
- Delegates responsibility.
- Sets economy on new path.
- Outmanoeuvres the Opposition.
- More democracy in the party.

MINUSES
- No progress on Kashmir, Punjab.
- Non-confrontation may cause vulnerability on certain issues.
- Follow-up on reforms tardy.
- Delay over crucial party matters.

Narasimha Rao knew 17 languages, but he didn't speak much. That was the trait that got him the job. Sonia Gandhi was traumatised by husband Rajiv's assassination and, a recluse herself, not initiated into the family vocation of her marital home. Taking over a minority government in stormy times was not an option. Someone who had never raised his voice as a cabinet minister under Indira and Rajiv—the classic, khadi-clad Congress amanuensis—seemed a safe choice. At worst, he would do nothing.

Initially, that forecast seemed accurate, and everything about this septuagenarian from Andhra Pradesh began bothering Delhi's power-watchers. As the first prime minister from South India, Rao anyway appeared foreign to those used to noisy bazookas from the Gangetic backyard. They couldn't decipher his gnomic silences, and they read his infamous pout as prevarication.

As it happened, Rao did *everything*. With an attitude that would amount to audacious if it did not come from such a savant, he bodily lifted India from the groove it had been on for over four decades—35 years later, we are still on it.

The economic liberalisation of 1991 may have been an idea whose time had pretty much broken through the front door, but Manmohan Singh as finance minister needed a carte blanche—and cover fire. India's mental axis was still attuned to the old socialist ways; even its foreign policy was wedded to 'bloc' thinking. His quiet ministrations undid all that inertia of habit. Even when they hounded him out with a hail of allegations, they hadn't quite fathomed that he had already changed their world. ■